



to a lesser extent PKL, Indian franchises continue to bleed money in other leagues. Rahul Todi of Shrachi Rarh (Bengal Tigers owner) felt the digital penetration in India and the bronze medals in Tokyo and Paris will help HIL 2.0 strike the right chord. Apart from the reduced cost due to the centralised venues, Todi also commended HI's decision to market the product by broadcasting the HIL on both Doordarshan and Sony Sports Network. The league will also be streamed on Prasar Bharati's OTT platform, Waves.

Apart from the centralised venues, broadcast strategy was another takeaway for the HIL governing committee. "The previous editions highlighted how a strong broadcast presence could significantly influence audience engagement and brand value. This time, the league aims to go beyond standard telecast practices, integrating advanced technology, expert analysis, and strategic marketing to enhance viewer experience and broaden reach," said Bhola Nath.

He also confirmed there will be 16 cameras deployed at each stadium and elaborated on the cutting-edge telecast experience that will be in place. "Advanced graphics will provide detailed insights into gameplay, such as goal breakdowns, player movements, passing speeds, angles, and the time taken by goalkeepers to make saves. Additionally, features like drag-flick and penalty stroke speed will be showcased, giving viewers a deeper understanding of the game's technical nuances."

Sony Sports Network, which came on board earlier this month as a broadcast partner, is optimistic about a boost in viewership due to India's recent success with both the men's and women's teams. "The interest in hockey has seen a rise since the Indian team won the bronze at the Olympic Games Tokyo 2020, which was their first Olympic medal in 40 years," said Rajesh Kaul, Sony Sports Network India's Chief Revenue Officer. "Hockey does not get the kind of viewership that cricket brings.

However, with the sport being on the rise, we are ahead of the curve with the broadcasting of hockey in India."

Divyanshu praised the broadcast model with DD and Sony Sports, saying it offers the opportunity to penetrate both rural and urban markets. He added, "Like it happens in all the leagues, there's a split between all the franchises and all the leagues. So that will happen. Currently, I'm not in a position to disclose all the numbers, because we also haven't received communication in terms of the media rights numbers."

Todi, who also co-owns the Indian Super League (ISL) club Mohammedan SC, said, "I think hockey will receive much more support centrally also. And I think it's very expensive because of the cost factor if you compare ISL costs and the ISL structure. I think that's where I would credit Hockey India for their cost structures. We find some of the things in ISL a little exaggerated in terms of what is practical for India. So I think HIL has been very mindful of this." While centralised venues mean lower costs, franchises can't tap into the fans' support in their home cities like Kolkata, Chennai, Haryana and Punjab. Only Odisha-based Kalinga Lancers will find itself at home in Rourkela, while the Rourkela-based women's team Odisha Warriors will play only one of its six matches in the city. "There are pluses and minuses [to the centralised venue]. In the long term, the home-and-away format is needed to build that sort of local connection and a local fan base to come and follow the sport. There's no dearth of people wanting to come and watch hockey. The only challenge is having the right atmosphere and moment for them to come and enjoy the sport. So, the sooner we can move to the home-and-away format, the better it would be for the league and the sport," said Singhania.

The right ingredients are in place for the HIL to recommence and have a successful first outing, but Hockey India will be keen to ensure it is more than just a one-hit wonder.